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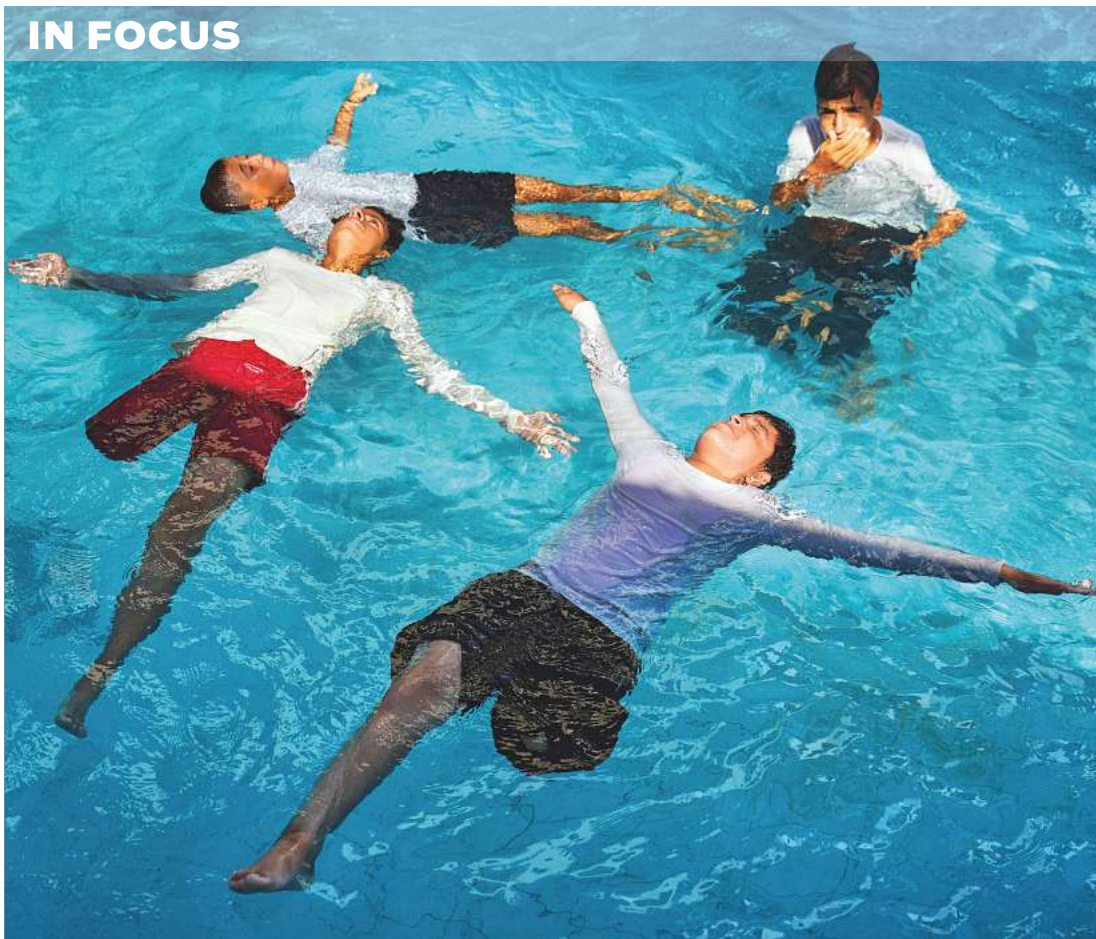


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IN FOCUS



GAZA'S CHILDREN FIND HOPE IN SWIMMING

Palestinian youth who lost limbs during the war are learning to swim in Khan Younis, finding moments of confidence and joy in the water | **P8-9**

Photo: AP

TRUMP: IRAN 'COLLAPSING' AMID 'ECONOMIC D-DAY'

Tehran defiant as US turns to financial warfare

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

US President Donald Trump declared yesterday that Iran was “completely collapsing” as Washington prepared to launch what it called an “economic D-Day” against Tehran, opening a new front in a nearly six-month war locked in military and diplomatic stalemate.

“IRAN IS COMPLETELY COLLAPSING!!!” Trump posted on Truth Social, hours after Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent promised the “single greatest financial offensive ever” against the Islamic Republic.

Bessent warned that countries continuing to enable Tehran risked becoming “global pariahs”, signalling that Washington could target governments, companies and financial networks helping Iran evade sanctions.

Oil lifeline squeezed

Iran responded defiantly. Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi portrayed the turn to financial warfare as evidence Washington had failed militarily.

Iran is already under severe pressure. Its oil exports through the Strait of Hormuz have

Iran's oil exports through the Strait of Hormuz have plunged from about 2 million barrels a day before the war to 400,000 by mid-August.

plunged from about 2 million barrels a day before the war to 400,000 by mid-August, according to maritime tracker Kpler — an 80 per cent fall.

The conflict has also kept global energy prices elevated. Brent crude was trading around \$91 a barrel yesterday, despite falling about 2 per cent as markets awaited details of Washington's new sanctions.

Yet whether even tougher measures can force Tehran to capitulate is uncertain. Iran has spent decades building a sanctions-evasion network involving front companies, brokers, exchange houses and a shadow tanker fleet using ship-to-ship transfers, altered tracking data and opaque documentation.

Payments can bypass the dollar through Chinese yuan and barter arrangements, energy strategist Umud Shokri told CNN. In 2024, \$9 billion in Iranian shadow-banking activity passed through US correspond-

ent accounts, according to the US Financial Crimes Enforcement Network. That resilience presents Trump with a problem: Tehran has repeatedly shown it can replace sanctioned tankers and shell companies and shift much of the economic pain onto its population.

Iranians bear the brunt

Ordinary Iranians are already struggling with soaring prices, a collapsing rial and increasingly unaffordable essentials.

“It's really very difficult. I don't think people can really take this much longer,” Sarah Hassanbeigi, a 32-year-old Tehran pharmacist, told AFP.

Economic hardship helped fuel massive anti-government protests in December and January, giving Tehran another reason to worry about further deterioration. For Trump, therefore, the test of “economic D-Day” is not simply whether he can make Iran poorer. It is whether Washington can finally make the regime — rather than principally its people — feel enough pain to change course.

Meanwhile, Trump spoke last week with Pakistan army chief Asim Munir, who travelled to Tehran yesterday as part of Islamabad's latest mediation effort, a US source told AFP.

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BUSINESS

Dubai-India trade more than doubles to Dh222.5b in a decade | P-1



SPORT

How F1 champion Norris aims to defend title in Abu Dhabi | P16

Know about right schoolbag weight, fees and switching academic tracks

With schools in UAE set to reopen, it is crucial to check expert and official guidelines

DUBAI/ABU DHABI

BY LAKSHANA N. PALAT
Assistant Features Editor
ABDULLA RASHEED
Abu Dhabi Editor

Could your child's schoolbag hurt their spine?

UAE experts have urged parents to follow the 10 per cent weight rule for schoolbags, as students gear up to get back to schools across the UAE.

A schoolbag can be one of the heaviest things your child carries, every day. Books, a laptop or tablet, water bottle, lunch box, pencil case, PE kit and all the things that somehow accumulate during a school week can quickly turn a manageable backpack into a substantial load.

And discomfort shouldn't just be dismissed as another rite of growing up. The question is: how heavy is too heavy, and when does a schoolbag stop being useful and start becoming a burden on a growing body?

The starting point, according to Dr Ravi Nayak, Specialist Orthopaedic Surgeon at Medcare Orthopaedics & Spine Hospital, is easy enough: aim for a schoolbag that weighs no more than around 10 per cent of the child's body



Virendra Saklani/Gulf News

■ Students of Delhi Private School, Sharjah, back to school after winter break.

weight. Physiotherapist Sofia Kia Turner agrees that 10 per cent is a useful practical target, while cautioning against treating any particular figure as a magical cut-off.

However, she does add that there isn't a scientifically proven point at which a schoolbag suddenly becomes dangerous.

Dr Nayak says parents should also weigh in how long a child carries the bag, whether they walk long distances, and whether they have any musculoskeletal concerns, bearing in mind that “younger children, however, may be less able to tolerate heavy loads because their bodies are still developing,” he says.

Six components

In what will be a relief to parents, the Abu Dhabi Department

of Education and Knowledge (ADEK) now requires private schools operating in the emirate to exempt parents from certain components of school fees relating to devices, textbooks, school uniforms and other items when students choose to use second-hand materials — such as resold or donated items — that meet the school's current requirements, including valid textbook editions and current uniform colours and designs.

According to ADEK's School Fees Policy, private schools are required to divide their approved fees into six components: tuition fees, educational resources fees, school uniform fees, transportation fees, extracurricular activity fees and other fees. Schools may also charge separate fees for board examinations.

Moving tracks

Meanwhile, the UAE Ministry of Education has set out new rules governing how students can move between academic tracks, with eligibility tied to grade level, academic performance and science subject requirements.

Under the study plan for the 2026-27 academic year, students may switch from one educational track to another only at the start of the school year and after meeting all approved requirements. Transfers will no longer be permitted after the first two weeks of the academic year.

SEE ALSO P2



Photos: Instagram/kaziahmejo

Born in UAE, crowned in Jaipur: The Miss Universe India story

UAE-born Kазiah Liz Mejo, a 19-year-old from Kerala, has been crowned Miss Universe India 2026 in Jaipur, India. Kазiah spent her formative years in Abu Dhabi, where she completed her schooling at Emirates National School, St Joseph's School and Abu Dhabi Indian School. Her upbringing in the UAE exposed her to a diverse, multicultural environment, which she has credited with helping shape her confidence, communication skills and outlook. **SEE ALSO P14**

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